

Release of Bahá'ís Arrested in Yemen

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

22 October 2008

To the followers of Bahá'u'lláh in Yemen

Dearly loved Friends,

With gladdened hearts we rejoice with you at the release of your devoted brethren who, after several months of incarceration, have now all been permitted to return to the embrace of their loved ones. We are moved, moreover, to express to your precious community our admiration for your steadfastness and courage. That you continued to discharge your spiritual obligations with unbending adherence to the Divine Teachings despite the ordeals confronting you is a tribute to the depth of your consecration. Recent events and your commendable response to them impel us to take this opportunity to convey our cherished hopes for your community and to reflect on the challenges before you.

The close association of your country with the Faith of Bahá'u'lláh dates back over half a century when many of your families settled in Yemen and made it your home. Others amongst you, exemplifying the purity of heart and spiritual capacities of the people of Yemen, sought the divine Light “from whatever lamp it may shine” and, exhibiting a remarkable freedom of spirit, were attracted to teachings that fulfil humankind’s highest ideals. With uprightness of character and conduct, you succeeded through the years to earn the respect and trust of your neighbours and acquaintances and to vindicate the reality of your faith. Scrupulously heeding the admonition of Bahá'u'lláh to be well-wishers of all, you remained aloof from the political and sectarian upheavals that erupted from time to time, and showed fidelity to the people of Yemen and its authorities.

Through the haze of the commotion surrounding recent events two points emerge with particular clarity. The first is that courageous souls from different walks of life were ready to offer you their genuine support and, in so doing, demonstrated the fair-mindedness and integrity of the Yemeni people. The second is that these events revealed the scope of the misunderstandings that exist about the aims of the Faith and, therefore, highlighted the magnitude of the work before you. The opportunity is now yours to seize. You must communicate to your countrymen the loftiness of your purpose: to unite the hearts through “holy words and pure and goodly deeds”. Share with them your unalterable belief in the oneness of humankind and your conviction that consciousness of this truth can banish hatred and fanaticism from the heart. Convey to your fellow citizens your abiding faith in their capacity to contribute to the advancement of spiritual and material civilization. And together with them bend your energies to selfless service for the progress of your society in the land you hold so dear.

That you may be confirmed in your current path, reinforced in your resolve and protected through the sustaining grace of the Ancient Beauty is our fervent entreaty at His Sacred Threshold.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]